

F2P Balance Manifesto — The "Skill, Not Stripe" Promise

The promise

You can reach the top 10% of the competitive ladder in Axie Duel without spending a single AXS, without owning a single Axie NFT, and without watching a single ad.

*NFT cards add **flavor, collectibility, and access to higher-stake tournaments** — not raw power.*

This is the line that separates Axie Duel from the 2021-era Web3 games that gave the genre a bad name.

Why this matters

The original Axie Infinity (2018-2022) suffered from a perception that became reality: *"You need to spend to play, and you need to spend more to win."* This drove away non-crypto gamers and even hurt the Web3 audience as the secondary market collapsed.

Axie Duel is built explicitly to **counter this narrative** while still giving NFT holders meaningful, mechanically-relevant utility.

The design rules (non-negotiable)

Rule 1: Stat ranges overlap

Card source	ATK range	DEF range	Notes
Starter cards (F2P)	1500-2200	1000-1900	Designed by hand for balance
Earned cards (post-pack)	1400-2400	900-2100	Wider variance, but no extreme outliers

Axie NFT cards	1500-2500	1000-2200	Algorithmic from parts; bounded by clamp()
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No NFT card has stats outside the band that any F2P player can match with starter + earned cards.

Rule 2: NFT effects are side-grades, not upgrades

NFT card effects are designed to be:

- **Conditional:** "When attacking a Plant Axie, +200 ATK" — situational, not always-on
- **Trade-offs:** "+300 ATK while in DEF position" — gives one thing, takes another
- **Anti-meta:** counters specific strategies but not all decks

Compare:

- **Starter card "Olek the Verdant Guardian"** (Plant L4): 1100/1700, no effect.
- **NFT Plant Axie L4** (algorithmic): 1100/1700, "Aura: +100 DEF to other Plants you control".

Both are L4 Plant tanks with similar raw stats. The NFT version has a *conditional* aura — useful in mono-Plant decks, useless in mixed decks. **A skilled F2P player with the starter Olek can match an NFT Plant Axie by playing tighter.**

Rule 3: No meta-defining "must-have" NFT cards

We commit to balancing such that **no NFT card becomes a "you must own this to compete"** scenario.

- Quarterly meta reviews using ladder + tournament data.
- If an NFT card type appears in >40% of top-10 decks, we adjust its effect (nerf or sidestep).
- F2P deck recipes published officially every 2 weeks showing competitive options.

Rule 4: Tournament accessibility

- **Free entry tournaments:** daily/weekly events with smaller prize pools, funded by platform/sponsors.
- **AXS-entry tournaments:** higher-stake events. **F2P players can earn AXS via:**
 - Daily quests (small but consistent)
 - Free tournament prize pools
 - Greenlight community grants (1-time)

- **No NFT requirement:** even AXS-entry tournaments accept anyone with the AXS, regardless of NFT ownership.

Rule 5: Ranked Premium tier — quality, not power

- **What it IS:** a separate matchmaking pool for NFT-linked accounts. Match quality is higher (less afkers, less abandoners).
- **What it is NOT:** a power tier. Premium tier players don't get card buffs, faster XP, or any in-match advantage.

This is a **collectibility incentive + signaling tier**, not a pay-to-win mechanism.

How we validate this in practice

Tournament data analysis (post-launch)

KPIs we'll track and publish quarterly:

- % of top-10 ladder players who are F2P (target: $\geq 30\%$)
- % of top-50 tournament finishers who are F2P (target: $\geq 40\%$)
- Average win rate of starter decks vs NFT decks (target: within $\pm 3\%$)
- "Must-include" cards by popularity in top decks (target: starter cards in top 10 by usage)

If any KPI fails, we **rebalance within 2 weeks** (cards or algorithm tweaks).

Public balance reviews

- **Monthly:** blog post with current meta snapshot + balance changes.
- **Quarterly:** full balance review + community vote on major changes.
- **Yearly:** rotation/sunset of overused cards (similar to Hearthstone Standard rotation).

Open balance philosophy

- **No hidden multipliers:** all card stats are public.
- **No matchmaking favoritism:** NFT holders don't get easier opponents.
- **No pay-to-cheat:** there is no version of "pay AXS to skip a turn" or "buy a power-up mid-match".

What NFT holders DO get (the value proposition)

So why bother owning Axie NFTs if F2P is competitive? **Five reasons:**

1. **Flavor + identity:** your Axie #5234 is *your* card with *your* parts and *your* effect. Personal, not generic.
2. **Collectibility:** rare parts → distinctive effects. Trading on Mavis Marketplace becomes more interesting because parts have gameplay differentiation.
3. **Tournament access:** higher prize pools (gated by AXS entry, not NFT, but NFT holders typically have AXS).
4. **Ranked Premium quality:** less abandoners, faster matches, signaling tier.
5. **Future utility:** minting your Axie-card to ERC-721 for trading, leasing, etc. (post-mainnet roadmap).

None of these is "raw power". All of them are reasonable reasons to engage with Web3 — without locking F2P players out of competition.

Why this is good for Sky Mavis

1. Counter the 2021 narrative

Sky Mavis publicly committed to making Axie sustainable, not extractive. **Axie Duel's F2P balance is concrete proof that Sky Mavis builders are aligned with that commitment.**

2. Expand the player base

By eliminating the "must-pay-to-play" friction, we open the funnel to:

- Casual TCG players from Hearthstone / Master Duel / etc
- Mobile gamers without Web3 onboarding
- Crypto-curious users who want to try before they buy

3. NFT demand from gameplay diversity

Because NFT cards are *side-grades* (each unique in flavor, not categorically stronger), demand shifts from "I need the strongest card" to "I want THIS specific Axie because its parts give an effect I love". This creates **more diverse demand** on Mavis Marketplace, not concentrated demand on a few "OP" cards.

4. Sustainable retention

F2P retention in TCGs is well-studied: ~30% of F2P players become spenders within 90 days *if the game respects them*. Axie Duel respects F2P players → higher long-term LTV.

The closing line for the pitch

"Axie Duel respects the F2P player's time and skill. NFTs add flavor, not advantage. This is how we earn back the trust of the post-2021 gaming audience — and how we earn the trust of Sky Mavis to give us the keys to the official Axie ecosystem."

Public commitment: this manifesto is part of the public repository. We will be held accountable to it.